

FDA Public-Hearing Dockets: Comment Volume Analysis

2008–Present | Data from regulations.gov API v4 | February 2026

Overview

We queried the regulations.gov API for all FDA Notice-type documents mentioning “public hearing” (and the variant “public hearing request for comments”) posted on or after January 1, 2008. After deduplication, this produced **584 unique dockets**.

For each docket, we counted total public comments by querying the `/v4/comments` endpoint for every document with an active comment period. Comment counts were summed across all documents within each docket.

Important Note: Search Precision and False Positives

The regulations.gov API’s `searchTerm` parameter performs **full-text search** across the entire document body—not a title-only filter. This means any FDA Notice that mentions the phrase “public hearing” anywhere in its text is returned, even if the document itself is not a hearing notice.

To identify likely false positives, we checked whether each docket’s notice title contained hearing-related keywords: “public hearing,” “hearing; request for comments,” “notice of hearing,” or “public meeting.”

Result: 523 of 584 dockets (90%) were flagged as probable false positives. The remaining 61 dockets have titles that explicitly reference a public hearing or public meeting.

Common false-positive categories include: advisory committee meeting notices (which reference hearing procedures in boilerplate text), patent extension determinations, debarment orders, and “Establishment of a Public Docket; Request for Comments” notices that solicit written comments but do not involve an actual hearing.

We present statistics both ways—all 584 dockets and the 61 confirmed hearing dockets—so the reader can assess impact with or without the false positives.

Summary Statistics

Metric	All Dockets (n=584)	Confirmed Hearings (n=61)
Mean	549.1	178.8
Median	2.5	25
75th percentile	20.0	85
90th percentile	109.0	385
95th percentile	384.7	1,222
99th percentile	3,925.6	1,841.6
6,950 comments → percentile rank	99.0%	100.0%

6,950 comments (docket FDA-2015-D-3719) falls at the 99th percentile across all 584 dockets and at the 100th percentile among the 61 confirmed hearing dockets — meaning it would be the single highest comment count in the confirmed set.

Top 10 Dockets by Comment Count (All Dockets)

Rank	Docket ID	Title	Comments
1	FDA-2021-N-1088	Vaccines and Related Biological Products Advisory Committe...	130,471
2	FDA-2017-D-6580	Drug Products Labeled as Homeopathic	50,011
3	FDA-2022-N-0082	Vaccines and Related Biological Products Advisory Committe...	42,638
4	FDA-2022-N-0904	Vaccines and Related Biological Products Advisory Committe...	30,624
5	FDA-2022-N-2810	Vaccines and Related Biological Products Advisory Committe...	20,927
6	FDA-2021-N-0357	Pharmacy Compounding Advisory Committee; Notice of Meeting...	10,891
7	FDA-2022-N-0336	Vaccines and Related Biological Products Advisory Committe...	2,499
8	FDA-2018-N-1621	Patient-Focused Drug Development on Chronic Pain; Public M...	2,450
9	FDA-2022-N-0905	Vaccines and Related Biological Products Advisory Committe...	1,607
10	FDA-2019-N-1646	Joint Meeting of the Drug Safety and Risk Management Advis...	1,498

Five of the top 10 are Vaccines and Related Biological Products Advisory Committee (VRBPAC) meetings, reflecting intense public engagement with FDA vaccine decisions during and after the COVID-19 pandemic. These dockets dominate the right tail of the distribution and significantly inflate the mean (549) relative to the median (2.5).

Top 10 Dockets by Comment Count (Confirmed Hearings Only)

Rank	Docket ID	Title	Comments
1	FDA-2018-N-1621	Patient-Focused Drug Development on Chronic Pain; Public M...	2,450
2	FDA-2018-N-2381	The Food and Drug Administration's Comprehensive, Multi-Ye...	1,436
3	FDA-2011-N-0656	Animal Drug User Fee Act; Public Meeting	1,286
4	FDA-2009-N-0143	Risk Evaluation and Mitigation Strategies for Certain Opio...	1,222
5	FDA-2013-N-0035	Considerations Regarding Food And Drug Administration Revi...	978
6	FDA-2010-N-0385	Food Labeling; Labeling of Food Made From AquAdvantage Sal...	484
7	FDA-2011-N-0400	Approaches to Reducing Sodium Consumption	385
8	FDA-2011-N-0143	Foreign Supplier Verification Program	336
9	FDA-2009-N-0247	FDA Transparency Task Force; Public Meeting	269
10	FDA-2012-N-1172	Impact of Approved Drug Labeling on Chronic Opioid Therapy...	251

Context: Docket FDA-2015-D-3719

Docket FDA-2015-D-3719 (“Draft Guidances Relating to the Regulation of Human Cells, Tissues, and Cellular and Tissue-Based Products”) received approximately **6,950 public comments**. This docket is a Draft Guidance, not a Notice, and therefore did not appear in our search results. However, its comment count serves as a useful benchmark.

Against the full set of 584 public-hearing-related dockets, 6,950 comments places at the **99th percentile**—only 6 of 584 dockets received more. Against the 61 confirmed hearing dockets, it would rank **1st**, exceeding the next-highest by a wide margin.

This level of engagement is exceptional by any measure. The only dockets surpassing it are driven by organized mass-comment campaigns (primarily related to COVID-19 vaccines), a dynamic qualitatively different from typical regulatory comment activity.

Methodology

Data source: regulations.gov API v4 (api.regulations.gov), queried February 2026.

Docket discovery: Searched `/v4/documents` for FDA Notices with `searchTerm=public+hearing` and `searchTerm=public+hearing+request+for+comments`, filtered to documents posted on or after January 1, 2008. Extracted and deduplicated parent docket IDs across both queries.

Comment counting: For each docket, retrieved all documents via `/v4/documents?filter[docketId]={id}`. For documents with a comment period (indicated by `openForComment` or `commentEndDate` fields), queried `/v4/comments?filter[commentOnId]={objectId}` and read `meta.totalElements`. Summed across all documents per docket.

Limitations: (1) The full-text search produces false positives; title-based filtering mitigates but may not eliminate all. (2) Some pre-2008 dockets appear because they were modified on regulations.gov after 2008. (3) Comment counts reflect submissions on documents with formal comment periods and may not capture all forms of public input (e.g., testimony submitted at in-person hearings).